



**Farm
Sustainability
Assessment**

BY SAI PLATFORM

Farm Sustainability Assessment Benchmarking Protocol

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1 Introduction

SAI Platform created the Farm Sustainability Assessment (FSA) 'to drive relevant and demonstrable continuous improvement of on-farm social, environmental, and business performance through supply chain engagement and fostering a common understanding of sustainable agriculture.' Part of this involves building better industry alignment. In this context the FSA provides a common reference point for farm sustainability schemes as well as a consistent approach to benchmarking against it.

An increasing number of businesses across the globe are using the FSA as their internal reference for sustainable farming and sourcing. To fulfil their objectives, they need a flexible approach that enables them to utilise a mix of sustainability schemes, initiatives and programmes. The FSA provides value by harmonising various approaches, bringing them all together under the same framework to identify the preferred approach for each company and supply chain.

Stakeholder consultations, learnings from the current system and the ISEAL Sustainability Benchmarking Good Practice Guide July 2019 were used to refresh and update the FSA3.0 benchmarking programme. Through benchmarking, SAI Platform hopes to:

- Reduce the need for farmers and businesses to use multiple sustainability schemes.
- Promote credible benchmarked schemes to the companies using the FSA.
- Reduce the number of company specific benchmarking exercises taking place duplicating efforts and resources.
- Create a level playing field making benchmarking results fair and consistent by standardising the approach.
- Reduce the proliferation of overlapping sustainability schemes.
- Avoid the direct implementation of the FSA competing with existing schemes.

Benchmarking involves a detailed analysis process, in which one of our approved benchmarking consultants looks closely at the content, assurance, and governance of a scheme, and compares it to that of the FSA. The outcome of the benchmark should tell FSA users and scheme owners:

- The level of SAQ coverage by the scheme's content, in relation to the FSAs Bronze, Silver and Gold performance thresholds.
- Which FSA questions are not already being addressed by the standard thus allowing farmer engagement to focus on those remaining.
- Whether the assurance of the scheme meets FSA verification minimum requirements.
- Whether the governance of the scheme meets FSA minimum requirements.

The FSA benchmarking protocol has been designed with reference to ISEALs Benchmarking Good Practice Guide.

2 Why use the benchmarking option.

For businesses, there are several reasons why it may be preferable to use an alternative sustainability scheme than opt for direct FSA implementation and verification. This will depend on individual circumstances and the needs of the supply chain. For example:

- There is already a sustainability scheme in place that farmers support and are engaged in.
- The company may wish to make consumer-facing claims and would prefer to use a sustainability scheme that supports this.
- There may be specific market drivers such as food safety, quality specifications, organic, or biofuels requirements found in some sustainable agriculture programmes which may have overlapping requirements, but differing objectives.
- There is a more specific scheme available for your crop, region, or sustainability priority.
- You require higher levels of assurance of either, farm performance or traceability than that which the FSA provides.

For scheme owners or users of those schemes, there are several benefits to benchmarking against the FSA. For example, it:

- Conveys a global level of industry recognition.
- Prevents the need for multiple unilateral benchmarking exercises with every stakeholder or scheme owner.
- Increases market access for users of your scheme.
- Provides insights for the further development of your scheme for continuous improvement, e.g. during standards setting or revision.
- Advertises your scheme to the SAI platform membership and FSA user base.
- Reduces the risk of competing or overlapping programmes being developed.

3 Document Purpose

This document describes:

- The aims and scope of the FSA Benchmarking programme
- How the FSA Benchmarking programme is governed and operates.
- In which situations FSA benchmarking is applicable and preferable.
- The process and methodology for benchmarking SAI Platform Farm Sustainability Assessment (FSA) against different sustainability schemes.
- How FSA Benchmarking results are determined
- How to make FSA equivalency claims.

For simplicity, the term Scheme is used to generically refer to a wider variety of approaches: company sustainability programs, company sourcing requirements, legislation, voluntary sustainability standards, programs, national schemes or curricula, among other diagnostic tools.

NOTE

The audience for this document is any stakeholder interested in knowing more about the FSA benchmarking programme and focuses on the needs of scheme owners and FSA users.

4 Benchmarking Applicability

The FSA Benchmarking programme is applicable to all farm level sustainability schemes including:

- Company schemes: A code of practice or set of requirements which form part of a farm level procurement strategy.
- Legislation: Farm level regulations set by international, national, or regional governing bodies, including criminal law, common law, directives, and voluntary farm subsidy schemes.
- Voluntary Standards: set of criteria defining social, environmental and/or economic practices in an industry or product supply chain (ISEAL).
- National schemes: Run by country level farmer association often supported by government.
- Diagnostic tools: For the purposes of training, educating, monitoring and evaluation, quantitative foot printing, or developing improvement plans.

5 Benchmarking Scope

The benchmark covers three overarching aspects of each sustainability scheme:

1. Scheme content as compared to the FSA3.0 Sustainable Agriculture Questions (SAQ) in terms of both:
 - Normative documents: the requirements, indicators, or sustainability performance levels delineated by the scheme or standard.
 - Informative documents: assessment guidance i.e., additional information about how the content requirements of the scheme should be interpreted.
2. Governance, as compared to FSA benchmarking governance criteria (Annex 1): How the scheme is structured, managed and implemented. The legitimacy of a sustainability scheme derives in part from its operating structure. It also encompasses the existence of checks and balances.
3. **Assurance system**, as compared to the FSA Implementation framework. I.e., the means of assessing the compliance of the scheme content requirements of a farm or farm groups attainment within the scheme. This will establish whether the scheme's level of assurance meets FSA minimum verification requirements. A summary and interpretation of the FSA implementation framework minimum verification requirements is available in Annex 2.

A single benchmarking exercise may include a combination of multiple schemes and may include legislation from the country of origin of production (see chapter 6). In such cases, each scheme will be evaluated independently, with respect to its content, assurance, and governance. However, the content of multiple schemes and legislation can be evaluated together to create a combined FSA equivalency result.

6 Benchmarking Results & Claims

The FSA benchmarked performance level (Bronze, Silver & Gold) is determined on the basis of the scheme's content as compared to the FSA3.0 Self-Assessment Questionnaire.

However, schemes or their users can only claim 'equivalency' to this benchmarked performance level if the scheme adheres to certain requirements in terms of its governance (Annex 1) and meets or exceeds the FSAs minimum verification requirements (Annex 2).

While schemes that do not have an assurance method which fulfils FSA verification requirements can still be benchmarked against the FSA and obtain a benchmarked performance level, they will only be able to claim that they are 'aligned' to the FSA and not full 'equivalency'. External communication of the benchmarked performance level is still dependent on the scheme meeting minimum governance requirements.

For schemes that do not reach the minimum criteria for scheme governance, SAI platform will not publish FSA benchmarking results and no external communication will be allowed. This is regardless of whether or not its assurance method fulfils FSA verification requirements.

A summary of the types of benchmarking status and the corresponding communication and claims privileges can be seen below:

		CLAIM	(1) FSA Aligned*	(2) FSA Equivalent*
Status	SAQ comparison completed		✓	✓
	Meets verification requirements		✗	✓
	Meets Governance Criteria		✓	✓
	Result published & external communication allowed		✓	✓
	FSA Equivalent Volume Claims allowed		✗	✓

* at Partial/ Bronze / Silver / Gold Level

Table 1: Communication Claims

Example statements to communicate benchmark claims:

- (1) Where the scheme does not meet the FSAs verification requirements the following claim can be made: *'X Scheme has been benchmarked against the FSA SAQ and is aligned to FSA X level on a content-only basis'*. The communication must refer to being applicable only to the scheme's 'content' concerning farm practices, and mention that FSA minimum verification requirements are not fulfilled. It must not use the word 'equivalent'.
- (2) When the scheme meets the FSA verification criteria, the following claim can be made: *'X scheme has been benchmarked against the FSA and is fully equivalent to FSA X Level'*.

Evidencing FSA Equivalent volumes via benchmarking:

You may be asked to provide evidence that volumes of raw material being sourced via benchmarked schemes are equivalent to a given FSA performance level. This could be for customers, or for the auditing of external company reports. To do so you will need to cross-reference two sources of information:

1. The form of proof used by the FSA benchmarked scheme:

FSA equivalent volume claims are only allowed for those schemes which have an assurance methodology meeting minimum FSA verification requirements. Such schemes will have procedures to give supply chain actors assurance that specified volumes have been grown according to its standards. This could be in the form of documented proof, e.g. a certificate or attestation issued by a 3rd party, or lists of qualified growers may be available via an open database.

The '[FSA Benchmarking Results](#)' document, available from the FSA Resource Centre:

AUDIT INFORMATION

The document contains all of the schemes with a current benchmark to the FSA and is the only official source of FSA benchmarking results. It clearly displays the scheme's name (column B) and the associated benchmarked result in terms of Not Yet Bronze, Bronze, Silver, or Gold (column M). Column I states the type of benchmarking claim that is permitted, depending on whether or not the scheme meets the FSA's minimum verification requirements; FSA Equivalent for those schemes that do meet the minimum verification requirements, and FSA Aligned for those that do not meet them.

Providing stakeholders with these two sources of information is all that is required to evidence FSA equivalent volumes via benchmarking.

7 Accounting for Legislation

FSA questions covered by national legislation that are not part of the sustainability scheme can only be included in the benchmark score in very low risk countries (annex 4) and low-risk countries, provided that the scheme has measures in place that help ensure producers comply with the law. This could be achieved by the scheme's operations, for example:

- publishing regulatory compliance training or guidance materials,
- raising awareness about upcoming changes to the law,
- having reporting channels back to scheme management for complaints about breaches in the law.

Or via specific provisions in the standard, such as:

- designated accountability for legal compliance to a single farm staff member,
- a general legal compliance requirement and passive monitoring during 3rd party farm audits,
- legal compliance requirements for specific farming practices and active monitoring during 3rd party farm audits.

For a list of countries by risk categorisation please see Annex 4. This list was determined using the services of CountryRisk.io.

Country Risk Status	Availability of legislation filters
Very Low	Yes
Low	Only for schemes that help ensure legal compliance.
Medium	No

Table 2: Risk Categorisation

User discretion is advised when accepting the benchmarking results that rely on legal filters. While the FSA benchmarking approach moderates the use of the legal filters, the risks cannot be eliminated or accounted for in every region, crop, or supply chain. Although the approach may be appropriate for some parts of a country, or for certain crops, it may not offer enough assurance of legal compliance in others. In such circumstances it is the responsibility of the users to conduct their own due diligence and determine if the level of risk is tolerable to their business.

ADVICE

For a global or regional standard, if legislation is included in the benchmark, it must be clearly stated which country/region that benchmark applies.

The legislation benchmarking can only consider compulsory measures but not other voluntary schemes, initiatives, or guidance. Furthermore, it must be noted that legislation alone, cannot be used as a substitute for the FSA, even if the score is bronze or above. It is critical that there are management and support systems in place for farmers, as well as a verification or assurance system, which is commonly provided in the presence of sustainability schemes.

There may be FSA questions that are not part of either legislation or the standard but could be seen as 'normal or common practice' in a country or region. This common practice cannot be considered in the benchmark. SAI Platform recommends that the common practices are added to the standard to ensure they are covered during the benchmark and to ensure they are truly complied with.

7.1 Country risk categorisation update frequency

The FSA is committed to updating the country risk classification (Annex 4) every 2 years, with the next update due in March 2027. This approach is designed to allow continuity for users that utilise legislative benchmarks, whilst also recognising the need to be dynamic in a world where the legislative environment can change quickly.

If the risk status of a country changes, EG. from Low Risk to Medium Risk, meaning legislative benchmarks will no longer be permitted in that country, users will be granted a one-year grace period. In this year, they can continue to use the legislative benchmark in the affected country; however, after the year ends, they will no longer be able to do so. Therefore, users will need to ensure that their supply base is verified using the FSA or is certified under a benchmarked scheme that has maintained its benchmarked equivalence level in the affected country in order to allow for a continuance in FSA claims.

Furthermore, to preserve the integrity of the FSA system, SAI Platform reserves the right to review the risk status of any country at any time. If the risk status of a country is downgraded and legislative benchmarking is no longer permitted in the affected country, the same one-year grace period applies.

In situations with extenuating circumstances, users can apply for a maximum 6-month extension to the one year grace period. To do so, they must email fsa@saipatform.org and explain their case. A decision will be made within 2 weeks of having received the request, and the user will be notified.

8 Benchmarking Process

The benchmarking process is summarised in the diagram below (Figure 1). Before deciding to pursue FSA benchmarking, it is advisable to contact SAI Platform via fsa@saipatform.org to learn about the benefits and answer any questions you may have. The time taken to complete the benchmarking process is variable, however typically benchmarks **can be completed within 8-12 weeks.**

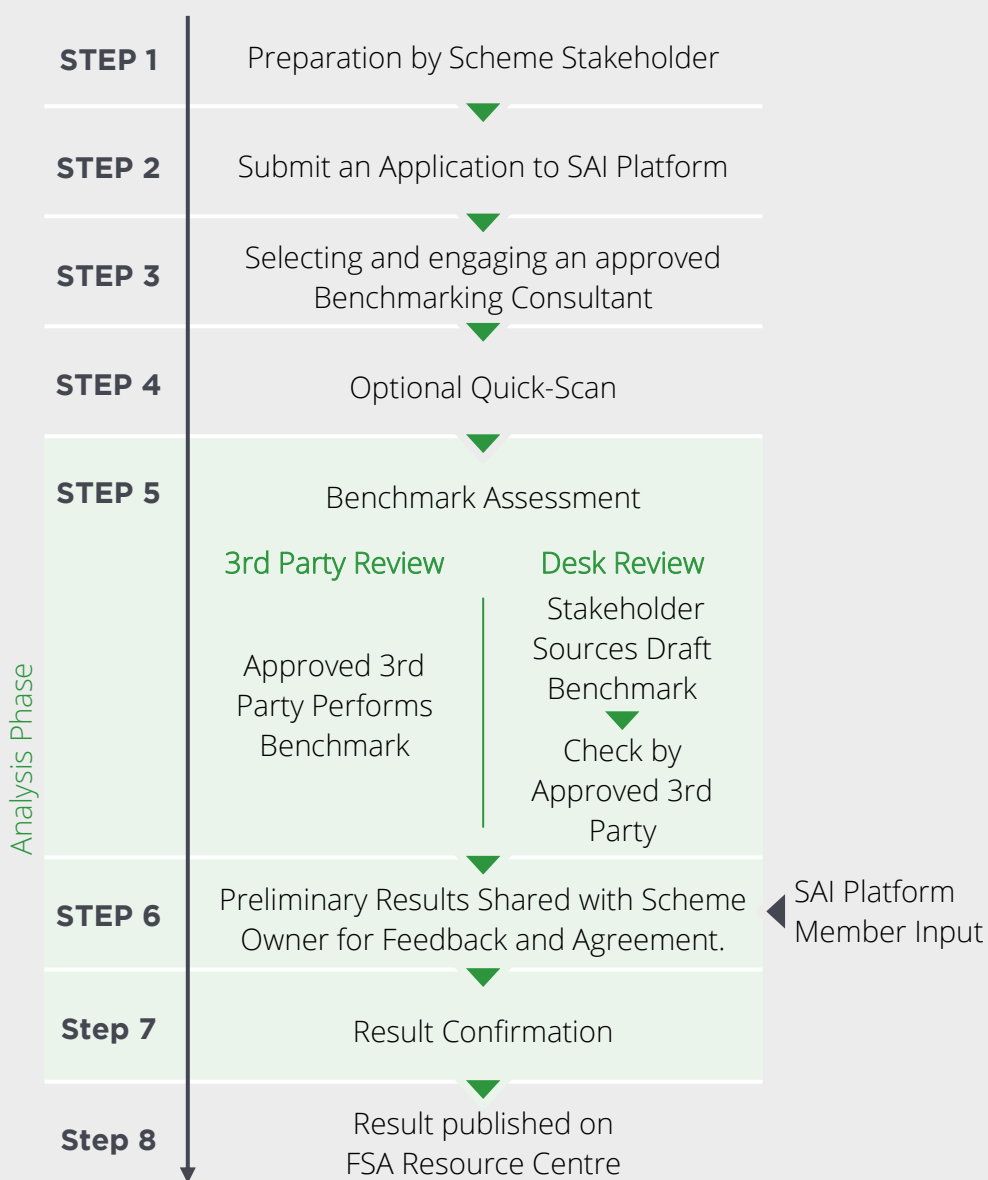


Fig. 1: Overview on Benchmarking Process

STEP 1: Preparation

Be informed: This document covers many of the frequently asked questions and is a good starting point. A member of the SAI Platform Secretariat can inform you about the benefits, fees, timelines, for benchmarking work. It's important at this stage to be informed about the governance and verification criteria for benchmarked schemes, and the types of claims that will be possible for your scheme.

Secure resources: Benchmarks can be funded by various stakeholders, but most typically are requested by either scheme owners or FSA users. It is important at this stage to secure funding.

Secure the commitment: Ensure the backing of your stakeholders, including the scheme owner who will be required to feedback on the benchmarking result before it can be published.

STEP 2: Submit an application to SAI Platform

Once a decision has been made to move forward, a simple application form should be filled in and sent to SAI Platform with the application fee. The application form covers the scope of the benchmark exercise i.e., content, assurance, and governance, as well as the intended type of claims.

STEP 3: Selecting and engaging an approved benchmarking consultant:

The next formal step is to select and engage an approved benchmarking consultant. who will provide a quote to oversee and conduct the benchmarking exercise. For more information on cost considerations please see Section 10.

The consultants approved to validate benchmarks are:

-  ADAS: Charles Ffoulkes: charles.ffaoulkes@adas.co.uk
-  CLM: Ine Spijkerman: ispijkerman@clm.nl
-  SureHarvest: Eric Harris: eharris@sureharvest.com

The applicant should contact an approved consultant to receive a quote to oversee the benchmarking exercise. For more information on costs please see Section 10. All contracting with the approved consultant should be done directly with the consultant.

STEP 4: Optional Quick Scan

An optional but recommended step is to perform a rapid assessment of the scheme to understand its potential to reach the desired or targeted FSA equivalence level and make equivalency claims. This can be built into the contract with the approved benchmarking consultant, or it can be conducted by the scheme/organisation itself.

STEP 5: Benchmark Assessment – Desk Review

There are two options to undertake the benchmark:

1. A first draft can be organised by the requesting organisation for a 'consistency check' by the approved benchmarking consultant. The draft can be undertaken by anyone, be it the scheme owner, scheme user, or another 3rd party consultant before submission to the approved benchmarking consultant.
2. The approved benchmarking consultant will conduct the whole benchmarking exercise.

If option 1 is chosen, the approved benchmarking consultant will provide the necessary excel templates as well as a self-benchmarking guide. They can support you should you have any questions. For either option, all coordination and agreements should be made directly with the approved benchmarking consultant.

Please see text box below for some tips in making this decision.

DECIDING WHETHER TO ORGANISE A 1ST DRAFT

Spending some time on this task to create a high-quality draft should result in time and cost savings later in the process; the more accurate it is, the quicker it will be for the approved consultant to approve the draft. Before getting started there are a couple of things to consider.

1. Will you use the benchmark to feed into the scheme's revision?

Going through the self-benchmarking exercise will give you a deeper understanding of how the FSA questions are composed. If following on from the benchmark you hope to align with any of the FSA questions or feedback into the scheme's revision, having this knowledge readily available is very convenient.

2. Is there anyone that you are aware of who could help?

If you are the user of a scheme, undertaking a self-benchmark may interest to the scheme owner. This also has the advantage of involving the scheme owner early on in the process, saving time when it comes to creating consensus on the final result.

3. How involved do you want to be?

Undertaking a first draft will give you the assurance that the result is as accurate as it can be, of course you will know your own scheme better than we do. However, there are some other important considerations:

- **Cost:** Undertaking a first draft of the benchmarking will reduce costs as it saves time for the approved benchmarking consultant.
- **Skillsets:** Benchmarking requires a level of interpretation as things are not always clear cut. Some prior knowledge of sustainable agricultural standards is recommended.
- **Timeline:** Hiring an approved benchmarking consultant to undertake the whole benchmark is typically faster than the DIY option. It also takes any pressure off your own capacity.
- **Flexibility:** Undertaking a self-benchmark gives you added flexibility. If during the benchmark you realise that equivalence to the FSA at the desired level is unlikely, you can pause the process and further evaluate options with your stakeholders avoiding any sunk costs.

Remember! If at any time circumstances change, you can always change course and ask the approved benchmarking consultant to take over at any point.

STEP 6: Feedback and agreement on results

This will involve a dialogue and feedback phase between the scheme owner and the consultant, where the results are discussed to improve the accuracy of the benchmark. Additional information may be requested. When a benchmark is not commissioned by the scheme owner it's the responsibility of the requesting organisation to engage the initiative of involving the scheme owner to solicit feedback.

Should a consensus not be reached between the approved benchmarking consultant and the scheme owner, SAI Platform will review the outcome in detail and make a recommendation. In the case of disagreement, the FSA Steering Committee will be convened on request to make a final judgement.

Benchmarking is rarely straightforward. In many cases, one FSA question is covered by several of the corresponding scheme criteria; some of which may be mandatory and others minor. Moreover, the risks related to an FSA question may be addressed without explicit reference to the practice(s). This is why in FSA benchmarking, the intent and design the schemes criteria are considered alongside the literal text. For example, it may be that many interrelated non-essential requirements can be used to justify that the FSA question is inevitably addressed by all farms in the scheme.

A GENERAL NOTE ON FSA BENCHMARKING

Before benchmarking results can be communicated, the scheme owner must agree with the result, and consent to its publication. A Benchmark License Agreement should be in place between SAI Platform and the Scheme.

Step 7: Result confirmation

Once agreement is reached between the scheme owner and the approved benchmarking consultant, the relevant documentation (completed benchmark spreadsheet, supporting documents and scheme description) is sent to SAI Platform Secretariat. The scheme owner will then receive a letter from SAI Platform which confirms the result. At this stage SAI platform will offer guidance and feedback regarding communication options and press release content, and consent is given to publish the result. Before the result can be published, there needs to be a Benchmark License Agreement in place between SAI Platform and the scheme owner.

Step 8: Result Publication

The score will be published in the FSA resource centre via inclusion in the 'FSA Benchmarking Results'. This is the only official source of FSA benchmarking results.

9 Length of validity

The benchmark equivalence result is approved for the scheme version referenced at the time of benchmarking and based on the current version of FSA.

It remains valid until either the FSA, or the benchmarked scheme is meaningfully updated in any way that alters the basis of the original determination of the equivalence result. Meaningful updates, can include but are not limited to actions that fundamentally change:

Content:

- The scheme's content as it relates to farm practices; for example, adding or removing practices.
- Criteria prioritisation; for example, the essential or non-essential rating of practices.
- Performance thresholds or scoring; for example, either due to a change in the number of criteria or the quantity needed to reach the performance threshold(s)
- Applicability of questions e.g., due to crop or regional scope changes
- FSA minimum verification requirements (Annex 1)

Requirements for Scheme Governance (Annex 2)

If there is a meaningful update of the FSA, or of the corresponding scheme, equivalence results will remain valid during an 18-month transition period after which the benchmark will need to be updated. It is recommended to engage in the update early in the transition period, in order to prevent any gap in equivalence status, and to secure that ample time to harmonise with FSA content should it be desired.

It is the responsibility of the organisation that signed the Benchmark License Agreement, to:

-  Inform SAI Platform of any meaningful update to the scheme.
-  Seek confirmation of the updated benchmark result with approved benchmarking consultant i.e., re-benchmarking.

10 Benchmarking Fees

There are three types of costs in the FSA Benchmarking programme:

1. One-off fee paid to paid to approved benchmarking consultants directly to oversee and validate the benchmarking exercise.
2. One-off application fee (€2,000) payable to SAI platform before commencing the benchmarking process.
3. Annual benchmarking licence fee (€2,000) payable to SAI platform to operate and maintain a credible FSA benchmarking programme.

Both the Application fee and Annual License fee are free for SAI platform members.

10.1 Approved Benchmarking Consultants fees

The quote to undertake or approve FSA benchmarks depends on several factors, including:

-  The complexity of the benchmark. For example:
-  How many schemes are to be included in the benchmark.
-  Whether the scheme has multiple performance thresholds.
-  Whether there are multiple regimes for individuals or groups

- Whether there are multiple modules or interpretations for different crops.
- Document and language availability e.g. are the scheme documents available in English
- Whether the benchmark needs to be updated due to revision of a scheme or it is a new benchmark. Influencing factors include.
 - The scale of the changes
 - how well the latest version has been referenced to the original.
- Whether feedback and engagement with the scheme owner will be organised by the requesting organisation (where this is not the scheme owner) or this process needs to be managed by the consultant.
- Whether a quick scan of the content is desired.
- Whether the consultant will produce the full benchmark or provide a 'consistency check' of an already available draft benchmark (see STEP 5, Section 6).

Applicants may contact more than one consultant, as each have different regional expertise, as well as to compare price.

Costs, payment, and time scales should be discussed and agreed upon directly with the approved benchmarking consultants. SAI Platform does not play a role in these commercial negotiations.

11 Governance

11.1 Publication rights

SAI Platforms FSA Benchmarking program is desk-based only and does not monitor or review the quality of the implementation or impacts of equivalent schemes. Provided that the information on the scheme is accurate and operational, the governance requirements for scheme owners should safeguard against poorly functioning schemes being awarded FSA benchmarked equivalent status. However, should SAI Platform become aware that an FSA benchmarked scheme is not operating in accordance with its documented procedures, SAI Platform maintains the right to remove the equivalence status of that scheme.

If at any time, the scheme owner wishes to be removed from the FSA benchmarking equivalency overview, it retains that right and should notify SAI Platform in writing.

11.2 Benchmarked consultant's competence programme

The legitimacy and value of the benchmarking process depends on the competence of the approved consultants to implement the process professionally and consistently.

SAI Platform approved benchmarking consultants all meet specific requirements around skills, experience, and impartiality.

For consistency of interpretation and calibration, SAI Platform facilitates a regular forum for benchmarking consultants to discuss benchmarking interpretation and its presidents as well as to build a body of knowledge for continuous improvement.

Annex 1: Glossary

ACTORS IN THE FSA BENCHMARKING PROGRAMME

- **Benchmarking consultant:** Approved independent consultancy firm for benchmarking or approving benchmarks between a Scheme and the FSA.
- **Key representative:** Equivalence Result Owner
- **Requesting organisation:** Organisation requesting a benchmark with the benchmarking consultants.
- **Scheme owner:** The organization that owns and is responsible for the development and maintenance of the Scheme.

GENERAL TERMS

- **Assurance:** The system by which compliance of a farm or farm group to the Scheme content requirements is assessed (Annex 2).
- **Benchmarking:** Comparison of a Scheme against the FSA 3.0 content, assurance and governance requirements.

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- **Self-benchmark/review:** A benchmark performed by any party that is not one of the benchmarking consultants. These benchmarks need to be reviewed by an approved consultant.
 - **Full benchmark:** A benchmark where an approved consultant takes care of the full benchmarking exercise.
 - **Benchmarking Fees:** Costs associated with the FSA Benchmarking programme, to be paid by the funding organisation.
 - **Country legislation:** Farm level regulations set by international, national, or regional governing bodies. Not all legislation is available as a legislation filter (Annex 3).
 - **Very Low Risk:** Countries with sufficient assurance in place to ensure legal compliance of the farmers.
 - **Low Risk:** Legislation accepted only when schemes help ensure legal compliance of the farmers.
 - **Medium Risk:** Countries with insufficient assurance in place; legislation won't be taken into account in the benchmarking process.
 - **FSA:** The Farm Sustainability Assessment is a set of questions to assess farmer sustainability on a variety of topics.
 - **Governance:** How the scheme is structured, managed and implemented (Annex 1).
 - **FSA equivalence:** Equivalency of the Scheme's content against the FSA3.0 SAQ (Annex 4).
 - **Bronze:** Lowest equivalence level, showing a solid base of good farming practices.
 - **Silver:** Equivalence level including more intermediate and advanced questions, resulting in sustainable farming practices.
 - **Gold:** The highest equivalency level, aiming for advanced practices for a sustainable agriculture.
 - **Performance level:** The levels within the FSA, determining how well the farmer or benchmarked Scheme scores on sustainability topics.
 - **Quick Scan:** Rapid assessment of the Scheme to determine the potential performance level or sustainability claims
 - **Scheme:** Umbrella term for company sustainability programs, company sourcing requirements, legislation, voluntary sustainability standards, programs, national schemes or curricula, among other diagnostic tools.
 - **Company schemes:** A code of practice or set of requirements which form part of a farm level procurement strategy.

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- **Diagnostic tools:** For the purposes of training, educating, monitoring and evaluation, quantitative foot printing, or developing improvement plans.
 - **Legislation:** Farm level regulations set by international, national, or regional governing bodies, including criminal law, common law, directives, and voluntary farm subsidy schemes.
 - **National schemes:** Run by country level farmer association, often supported by government.
 - **Voluntary standards:** Set of criteria defining social, environmental and/or economic practices in an industry or product supply chain.
 - **Scheme documents:** All documentation regarding Scheme content, assurance and governance, to be used in the benchmarking exercise.
 - **Sustainability claims:** The claims that can be made in external communication regarding the performance level of a benchmarked Scheme (see chapter 6).
 - **Traceability:** A system that makes it possible to trace a product through the farm or supply chain.

Annex 2: Benchmarking criteria for Scheme Governance

To be eligible to make FSA benchmarked claims, schemes must have several operational and governance requirements in place. This is important to safeguard the credibility of the FSA benchmarking programme and the FSA as a system more broadly.

Mandatory criteria are pre-requisites to be included in the benchmarking overview. While it is possible to undertake the FSA benchmarking process without these being in place, they will need to be confirmed to be incorporated in the scheme before the result can be published and FSA benchmarking equivalence claims made. Monitored Criteria are those which are recommended but not required. SAI Platform will continue to evaluate the performance of benchmarked scheme owners in these areas, but no immediate action is required to address them. They may be considered for mandatory inclusion in our eligibility requirements for scheme governance at a later stage.

Mandatory requirements:

1. Scheme Management

- Publicly stated sustainability-orientated goals or objectives.
- A documented governance or management structure.
- Is able to declare income sources or funding model.

2. Standard setting

- Availability of the schemes content requirements on request
- A revision frequency not exceeding 5 years.

Monitored criteria:

1. Standard setting

- Public-consultation process that record and openly respond to input.

2. The degree to which the scheme embodies approaches related to:

- Priority setting
- Continuous Improvement
- Outcome Measurement

Annex 3: Benchmarking interpretation for FSA minimum verification requirements

Mandatory Requirements

- 1.** Documented assurance methodology for farm performance that meets FSA verification module minimum specifications:
 - a.** On farm 3rd party auditing
 - b.** Farm self-assessment and verification sample sizes in a given farm group are met or exceeded over a 3-year period.
- 2.** Documented methodology for how compliance with the standard is determined (e.g. scoring methodology).
- 3.** Documented minimum qualifications and competencies for auditors.

4. Documented means to deliver auditor training to ensure consistency.
5. Defined duration for the validity of claims.
6. Documented process to address any non-compliance or revoke status. of scheme operators.
7. Traceability
 - There is at minimum a mass-balance Volume Accounting System based on the Quantity Credit Method
 - There are written definitions and procedures for managing the Volume Accounting System.

Monitored criteria:

1. Documented transparent complaints or appeals process.
2. Availability of an open register of audited entities
3. There is an oversight mechanism to review the performance of assurance bodies or auditors.

Annex 4: Country Legal Compliance Risk Status

Very Low Risk	Low Risk
Australia	Chile
Austria	Costa Rica
Belgium	Czechia
Canada	Israel
Denmark	Italy
Estonia	Korea, Republic of
Finland	Latvia
France	Lithuania
Germany	Malta
Japan	Poland
Liechtenstein	Portugal
Luxembourg	Seychelles
Netherlands	Singapore
New Caledonia	Slovakia
New Zealand	Slovenia
Norway	Spain
San Marino	Taiwan, Province of China
Sweden	United States of America
Switzerland	Uruguay
United Kingdom	

Annex 5: Performance Level Result Calculation

SAI Platform's FSA3.0 contains three levels of questions: Essential, Intermediate, and Advanced. It is an objective of benchmarking to determine how many of each are addressed in order to give it an equivalence score i.e., FSA Bronze, Silver or Gold. The equivalence thresholds of each can be seen in the diagram below.

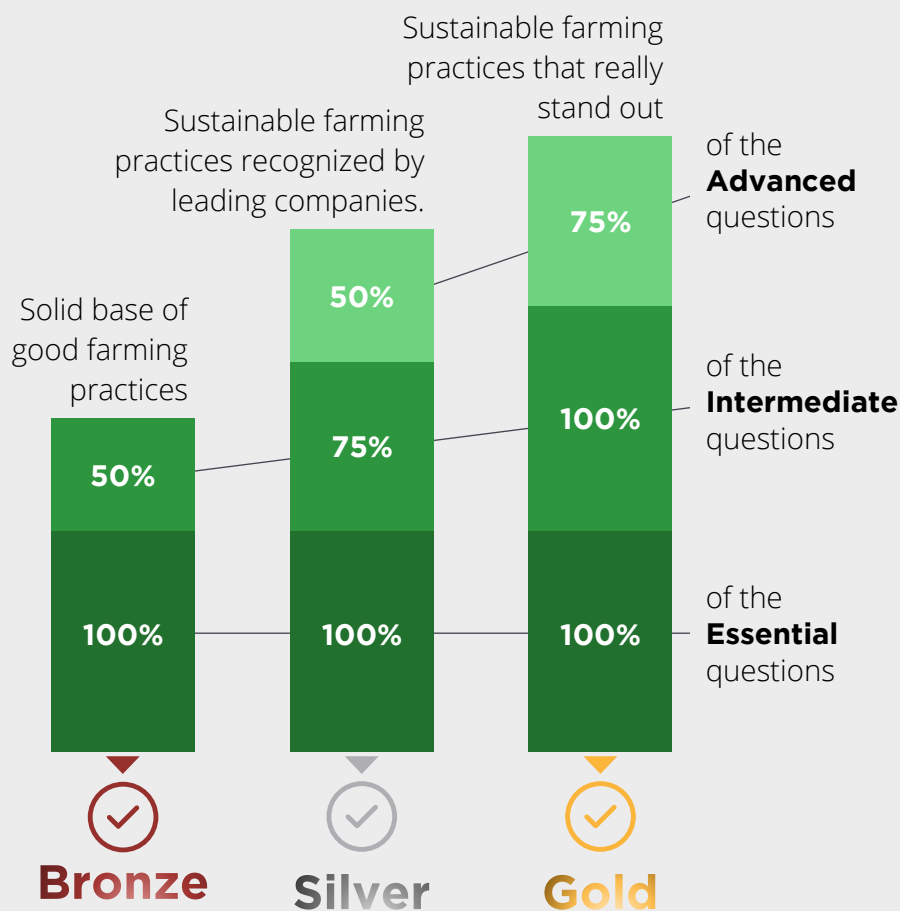


Fig. 2: FSA Performance Scores

STEP 1: The degree of content overlap

The first step in determining the FSA equivalence is to understand the number of FSA questions that are covered.

Each FSA question is assessed individually on its coverage by the **scheme under review**. The possible scores are “Yes”, “No”, “Partly” or “Not Applicable”.

These have the following significance:

- **Yes:** The scheme covers 100%, or is more ambitious than the FSA
- **No:** The scheme does not cover the FSA question
- **Partly:** The scheme covers only some of the issues included in the FSA question.
- **Not Applicable:** An FSA question contains topics that are not relevant to the agricultural production system covered by the scheme (e.g., questions related to irrigation if irrigation is not used)

When scoring a benchmark, “Yes” is 1 point, “Not Applicable” is 1 point, “Partly” is 0.5 points, and “No” is 0 points.

This exercise will tell us the maximum equivalence score for the scheme if all points are addressed.

STEP 2: Ambition

Criteria priority

The next step in calculating the score involves weighting the results downward, depending on the nature of the criteria in the scheme, and the number of criteria that are needed for each performance threshold. This will tell us the minimum FSA equivalence score conferred by the scheme for its performance threshold(s), which is the result that is communicated and used for the basis of equivalency claims.

Most schemes prioritise their criteria in some way. A typical example is as follows:

- Mandatory/major criteria or ‘musts’ – typically 100% compliance is required.
- Minor criteria or ‘should’ – often a certain x% of compliance is required; some standards require that a farmer must meet all these minor criteria in a specified timeframe.
- Recommendations – adherence is generally not required.

So, for example where only 80% of minor criteria are required to meet the schemes performance threshold, all “Yes” answers, which if covered by a mandatory criterion score 1 point, would only score 0.8.

If all criteria in the scheme are mandatory, then there will be no difference between the minimum and maximum scores. However, essential questions are covered by minor criteria with only x% compliance required, the scheme will be precluded from FSA Bronze equivalence, which requires 100% of essential questions to be addressed.

Recommendations may be included in the benchmark for the purpose of referencing but are not considered in the scoring of the benchmark.

Performance thresholds

If a scheme has various performance levels like the FSA, then a separate scoring analysis will need to be undertaken for each level. This includes those schemes which phase in requirements over time, with more becoming mandatory after so many years of being in the scheme.

Some schemes, that take a fully diagnostic or continuous improvement approach do not set performance thresholds, and hence typically rely on a self-assessed assurance model. This is because they are intended to stimulate learning, awareness, and inform sustainability priorities, rather than guarantee farm sustainability performance to the supply chain or consumer. In these cases, the maximum FSA equivalence score is published with the caveat that the schemes scope is benchmarked ‘up to’ FSA X Level and is also unverified. Should the users of these types of schemes wish to make FSA equivalence claims, then there would need to be a method to calculate FSA performance on an individual farm basis. This would need to be incorporated into the benchmark, and minimum verification requirements followed.

Benchmarking Continuous Improvement schemes or diagnostic tools and making FSA equivalency claims.

- To establish a minimum FSA equivalence level for all farms in the scheme, it requires the scheme to have a performance threshold and scoring methodology.
- Without it the performance of each farm in the scheme must be individually scored against the FSA using the benchmark.
- For small numbers of farms this can be undertaken manually, based on the benchmark however for a more scalable approach scheme owners can build an FSA equivalence scoring engine.
- For this to work well it typically requires an IT solution.
- In effect, this integrates the FSA scoring approach with user facing continuous improvement scheme.
- This exercise is not a small undertaking and a bespoke agreement would need to be in place with an FSA benchmarking consultant to develop it.
- It changes the way that the benchmark needs to be conducted. Typically, we seek to include as many references as possible in the benchmarking exercise to maximise the justification of FSA question level equivalence. To develop the scoring engine, we need to know the minimum number and combination of criteria needed to address the FSA questions for each (or the desired) FSA performance level. Establishing this is a complex process.
- The responses in the calculator can be verified using the FSA verification module without farms needing to be aware of the FSA questionnaire.
- Despite the added complexity there are several benefits:
- Schemes do not need to develop their own performance thresholds or verification requirements.
- Farms do not need to be aware of the FSA, they can continue to use the continuous improvement scheme that they know. It can happen behind the scenes.
- It allows a much more granular view of FSA equivalence for each farm depending on their performance in the continuous improvement scheme.